

unheard of and is often employed in public places like nightclubs.

Weight: The portability of a projector becomes a point of concern if you are the travelling type. Anything more than two kg should generally be shunned. Some projectors come along with a card readers that can handle CF cards or SD cards—these let you carry your presentation on handy flash cards and you no longer need to lug your laptop along for the meeting! Another boon for the traveller is a wireless projector—an ideal mate for an Intel Centrino-based laptop or a similar WiFi match.

The factors listed above serve as a level-one filter when making a buying decision for a projector. Once you have decided on the right combination of the features and settled on a price, you will still have other choices to make (more, if you look to the grey market). To further refine your needs, consider these “bonus features”, if you will:

Keystone correction: An image that is not completely square is a result of the keystone effect. This happens if your projector is not perpendicular to the screen upon which it projects, making for a trapezoidal image. Look for a projector that includes either a horizontal keystone correction feature (when projecting downward or upward) or a vertical one (when projecting sideways to a screen).

Contrast: The ratio between the lightest and the darkest areas of an image, the contrast should be at least 400:1. If you are projecting in a dark or dimly lit room, the contrast ratio will not be as high as when you are projecting in a well-lit room.

Video signals: Most projectors can handle both composite and S-Video transmissions. Some projectors can also handle “component” video, and these should be considered if your source or presentation supports it—as they give images of a higher quality. See box: “Demystifying Component Video” for more about this.

Computer ports: If you need to connect multiple sources to your projector, the unit must have the required number of ports. For example,



Aspect Ratio Or Resolution?

Deciding between the aspect ratio and the resolution of a projector is a bit tricky. Presentations are always made with a 4:3 aspect ratio, whereas movies are to be enjoyed in the 16:9 ratio. As far as resolution goes, as a rule of thumb, higher is always better. Therefore, if the projector is meant for purely presentation purposes, one with an aspect ratio of 4:3 and a native resolution of SVGA or more is preferable.

However, if the projector will be also used for presenting corporate videos shot in the wide-angle format, your projector should also be capable of 16:9 display. If a projector has a native resolution of 1,024x768—which is a 4:3 ratio—when switched to 16:9, it will display images at 1,024x576. If this projector had a native aspect ratio of 16:9 with a resolution of 1,024x576, switching it to 4:3 will give a smaller image of 768x576, and cost more than a native 4:3.

It is, therefore, better to buy a 4:3 aspect ratio projector that can also display 16:9 ratio frames.

if you plan to present alternating from your laptop and PC, the projector needs to have at least two video ports.

Rear projection: If you want your projector to display from behind a screen, it should be capable of inverting the image before projecting. Look for rear-projecting units to give you this feature.

Zoom lens: A zoom lens alleviates the need to shift your projector to increase or decrease the size of a projected image. A projector with a 1.2X zoom lens will increase image size by 20 per cent. This is vital to fill a fixed screen size from a given distance.

To sum it all up: Resolution and brightness are vital; the more the better and the more expensive your purchase will be. Contrast ratio is also important, especially if your presentations happen in bright rooms.

With that aside, here is a look at some of the projectors officially available in the market today. To understand the testing process, please refer “How We Tested And Awarded”.



Infocus X2

Desktop Projectors

A “desktop” projector is generally a large unit not designed to be portable. Of a total of nine brands in the market, we got a unit each—three were LCD models while the other six were DLP solutions. All of them were SVGA projectors with a 4:3 native aspect ratio (see box “Aspect Ratio or Resolution” for more on aspect ratio) while a few came with a selectable aspect ratio of 16:9. Their lumen rating ranged from 1,200 to 1,600, and contrast ratios ranged from 300:1 to 500:1.

What Did They Offer?

Since we set a cut-off price of Rs 1 lakh for this category, none of the XGA projectors made it to this section.

Image Size

The Acer PD113 alongside the Infocus X2 shared the highest lumen rating of 1,600. Both these models are DLP projectors and need 200 W for the lamp. From the three LCD projectors, the Sharp PG-B10S with 1,200 lumen (130 W for the lamp) and the Canon LV-S3 (160 W for the lamp) with 1,250 lumen, required a lot more power

Demystifying Component Video

The image captured by a video camera is in the RGB format. Passing the three colour signals separately will improve the image quality, but doing it without compression is a bad idea as it consumes lots of bandwidth. Component video solves this problem by compressing an RGB signal and delivering it to the projector.

The component signals communicate the luminance in an image and the colour information. Luminance is denoted by Y, whereas the other two signals, which are red and blue, are denoted by R-Y and B-Y. Since a projector already has luminance and red and blue colour information, it simply needs to fill the

rest of the scene with green. So the green signal is not transmitted, saving on bandwidth.

A component video signal is denoted as YPbPr for an analogue and YCbCr for a digital connection. Most DVD players have a component video output.

DVD players and projectors that support it show colour-coded jacks on it. There are entry-level projectors in the market that take a component signal only through the 15-pin D-Sub connector found on the graphics card of a PC. If a DVD player is needed to be connected to such a projector, it will require a special D-Sub-to-three-RCA jack cable to project an image.